Chapter Fifty-Two

The Lion's Den

Between 1252 and 1273,
three popes work to separate Sicily
from the empire,
the king of England tries to face down
his barons,
and the line of Frederick II comes to a
violent end

AFTER THE DEATH of his enemy Frederick II, Pope Innocent IV had returned triumphantly to Rome. "To the Roman Pontiff, all the kings of the Christian people are to be subject," wrote Thomas Aquinas; and Innocent IV agreed. "Whoever seeks to evade the authority of the vicar of Christ," he declared, "thereby impairs the authority of Christ Himself. The King of kings . . . has conferred full power on us."[1]

He used this power, at once, in two different directions. In 1252, he issued the papal bull *Ad Extirpanda*, an elaborate set of procedures governing the Inquisition in Italy. Every ruling civil official was ordered to appoint committees that would be responsible for hunting out and arresting heretics. And the officials themselves were commanded to "force" the heretics to confess, *citra membri diminutionem, et mortis periculum:* by any measure,